

BIOL 111-101 Syllabus – Fall 2026

Acknowledgements:

UBC's Point Grey Campus is located on the traditional, ancestral, and unceded territory of the xwməθkwəyəm (Musqueam) people. The land on which it is situated has always been a place of learning for the Musqueam people, who for millennia have passed on their culture, history, and traditions from one generation to the next on this site.

1. Course Information

Course Title	Course Code	Value
Introduction to Modern Biology	BIOL111 section 102	3 credits

Day and Times	Location
Tuesdays and Thursdays, 2:00 pm - 3:30 pm	Gordon Shrum Building, B1001

*Lectures will be recorded and live-streamed (Panopto link is posted on Canvas homepage):

Eligibility: Open to students who do not have credit for Biology 12 (including AP, IB) or BIOL 112 and require BIOL 111 as a prerequisite for BIOL 112, 121, and 180.

Overall Goals of BIOL 111

The overarching goal of BIOL 111 is to provide you with a fundamental understanding of the characteristics of life and some basic concepts in genetics, evolution, and ecology. Several specific course goals are for you to:

- Achieve an understanding of the core concepts in biology that are required for other biology courses and /or for science majors.
- Acquire a lasting knowledge and appreciation for living organisms.
- Appreciate how biologists, as scientists, understand the world.

Please refer to the lecture slides and the Canvas homepage for specific learning objectives, which I will be updating as needed.

By the end of Biol 111, we expect you to be able to apply your knowledge of the basic characteristics of life, genetics, evolution, and ecology to new scenarios, and to use your knowledge to answer questions, solve problems and/or make predictions based on biological scenarios.

2. Your Teaching Team

Name	Role	Contact Information
Lynn Norman <i>Office Hours: Fridays @ 1pm in Biol1114 or Zoom by request</i>	Instructor	lynn.norman@ubc.ca , Office - BIOL2103
Reilly Perovich Office Hours: Thursdays, 12:30 - 1:30 pm in Biol1114, or via Zoom by request		reillyjp@mail.ubc.ca
César Cabra Arias (from section 101) Office Hours: Thursdays, 12:30 - 1:30 pm Biol1114, or via Zoom by request	TA	cabra@zoology.ubc.ca
Zoom link: https://ubc.zoom.us/j/64824433864?pwd=rsxXRK8r80ybiCfhtC5j8SebXXnWNT.1		

3. Getting help outside of class time

Office Hours

- Office hours will start the week of September 14th
- Details are posted above and on Canvas.
- I also have an open-door policy; so, if you have questions, please drop by my office or send me an email.

Email

- Please feel free to email Cesar or me if you need help. Our email addresses are posted above and will be posted on the Canvas homepage. We will try to respond to emails within 24 hours. If you have not received a response to an email within 48 hours, please email us again.

Piazza

- Piazza is a discussion forum on Canvas where you can ask questions related to Biology 111 that can be seen and answered by your peers as well as by the teaching team. Piazza can be accessed via the course Canvas site (link on the left side of the screen) once the Canvas site is available.
- Please consider posting questions on Piazza so that other students can potentially benefit from the conversation.

4. Course Materials

- a) **Textbook** – not required. However, there is an online, freely available textbook that you can access if you have questions: Concepts of Biology <https://openstax.org/details/books/concepts-biology>
- This text goes into more detail that is testable for BIOL111. Rule – if I don't lecture on a subject, it is not testable.

b) The BIOL111 **Canvas site** should be accessible at www.canvas.ubc.ca by using your CWL login name and password.

- Lectures will be recorded and live-streamed. The link for the Panopto recordings and live streams of lectures is located on the Canvas home page.
- I will post pre-lecture slides (hopefully the night before the lecture, but it may be in the morning). I will also post post-lecture slides after class. Please watch for version numbers in the file names for pre- and post-lecture slides, just in case there has been an update.
- Assignments (e.g. quizzes and worksheets), practice questions, and announcements will also be posted on Canvas. Details to follow.

c) **iClicker Cloud** (optional): I will be asking iClicker questions in every lecture to give everyone an opportunity to apply their understanding of the concept being discussed to a novel scenario. It also lets me know if we need to spend a bit more time discussing a topic or not.

- Participation in iClicker questions is not worth any marks.
- You can join by clicking on this link: <https://join.iclicker.com/QWXU> [Links to an external site.](#) The link will also be on the Canvas homepage.
- You can join the class by logging into your iClicker account and clicking on the course name and "join".
- If you do not yet have an iClicker account - to set up your account: <https://lthub.ubc.ca/guides/iclicker-cloud-student-guide>

5. How You Will Be Evaluated

Assessment	Mark allocation
Weekly Quizzes (due Sunday nights @ 11:59 pm)	5%
Weekly Worksheets. Tentatively, most worksheets will be completed in class, but I will ask everyone to submit all worksheets onto Canvas. (Due Sunday nights @ 11:59 pm)	10%
GenEvoEco Assignment (due date TBA)	15%
Midterm exam – tentatively Tuesday, October 27 th during class time	25%
Final Exam – date TBA	45%
Exit card - optional (bonus 1%)	Bonus 1%

Details of Mark Breakdown:

1. Canvas Quizzes (5%) –

- Each unit will have associated Canvas quizzes. You can find links to the quizzes under the Assignments heading and the quizzes module.
- These quizzes allow you to check your understanding of the course concepts.
- You will have unlimited attempts at each Canvas quiz. The highest mark is recorded. You will have 60 minutes to complete each quiz.
- The quizzes will be due on **Sunday at 11:59 pm**, Vancouver time. .
- Answers will be released the day after the due date.

Important note: Canvas quiz questions are lower-level questions (e.g., recall, comprehension). At least some of the exam questions will be higher-level questions (apply, analyze, evaluate, explain, justify).

2. Worksheets (10%)

- I hope to dedicate at least part of each class to completing worksheets. These worksheets will give you the opportunity to practice some of the concepts covered in class.
- All of the worksheets will be available on the Canvas Homepage either under the Assignments heading or in the Worksheet modules (still to be created). I will bring some hard copies to class. I will find a way to provide an electronic link during the first week of classes (i.e. while Canvas is still not available). The worksheets will be due on **Sundays at 11:59 pm**, Vancouver time. The worksheets should be submitted to Canvas.
- Marks are for meaningful completion only (i.e., all questions answered to the best of your ability), so please try your best, and feel free to work with others, or get help on these if you're stuck.
- Marking keys for the worksheets will be posted after the due dates.

The following assignment will be marked based on meaningful completion (i.e. all questions/requirements answered to the best of your ability) and will be submitted to Canvas. This is still being written.

3. Geno/Evo/Eco Project (15%) – Individual or Group Assignment

- This project is still being written. Details will be posted on Canvas by the end of the third week of classes.
- Individuals or groups will be asked to visit the Beaty Museum, the Pacific Museum of the Earth, and to walk around campus or Pacific Spirit Park, and answer a few questions at these sites.
- This will require an iNaturalist account. iNaturalist will provide a list of identified species, which will be uploaded onto Canvas.
- This project will be submitted to Canvas.
- Due date for this assignment TBA, but will be towards the end of term. But, please keep in mind that Vancouver receives a lot of rain in the Fall, so perhaps take your photos a bit earlier in the term.
- Marks are for meaningful completion (i.e. all questions answered to the best of your ability) when available.

4. Optional Assignment - Exit Card (max. of a 1% bonus mark)

- The purpose of this optional assignment is to give you the opportunity to share with me one of the key points that you took away from taking Biol111. Examples of topics could be a concept or story discussed in class, one of the organisms mentioned, something that you found surprising, etc.
- I encourage everyone to be creative, but this is not necessary or full marks.
- The directions for this assignment will be posted on Canvas as soon as they are available.
- This is an optional, individual assignment.

5. Exams (70%)

There will be one midterm exam and one final exam in Biology 111. For both exams, the format will likely include multiple-choice, select-all, true/false, drawing, short-answer, and longer-answer questions. Some questions will be problem-based (e.g., explain, predict, justify). The exams will be closed-book. However, you can bring one 8.5 x 11" study sheet with any handwritten notes (your handwriting) on both sides. Please know that you can write your study sheet on an electronic device, but the text must still be in your handwriting, and you must bring a hard copy to the exam. Your study sheet may not include images from my lecture slides or from the web. The inclusion of this content would be considered academic dishonesty.

Exam	Weight	When	Content (tentative)
Midterm	25%	Tentative Date: Tuesday, October 27 th In class, regular class time. Duration: ~90 minutes Everyone can bring in one 8.5 x 11" (both sides) handwritten study sheet. See restrictions above.	Testable content from the Genetics Unit and part of the Evolution Unit. Characteristics of Life, terminology associated with chromosomes (e.g. ploidy and haploid number, homologous, sister chromatids), genes/alleles, mitosis, meiosis, genetic crosses, modes of inheritance, and pedigrees. Evidence for evolution, evolutionary mechanisms. Evolutionary content that will likely not be tested until the final exam = phylogenetic trees, species concepts and speciation. A list of learning objectives will be posted on the Canvas homepage after the Canvas page is available. The learning objectives may be modified based on what we cover in lecture.
Final Exam	45%	Final exam period. Date and location TBA. One 8.5 x 11" handwritten study sheet is allowed. Duration: 2.5 hours	Comprehensive (genetics, evolution and ecology), but with greater weight on the testable content after the midterm.

- **Missed midterm exam policy:** There is no make-up midterm. If you miss the midterm and have a valid excuse, please contact me immediately. If you qualify for a midterm exemption, the weight for the missed midterm will be transferred to your final exam.
- **Policy for contesting grading** on the midterm exam: You will be given the option of reviewing your marked exam. If you submit your exam for re-grading, the entire exam will be re-marked, and the new grade will be your final grade for that exam, whether it increases, decreases, or remains the same.
- **Missed final exam policy:** If you miss the final exam, please email me immediately, then contact the Dean's Office in your Faculty to determine if you will be allowed to write a deferred final exam. Exam deferrals are typically granted only to students in good standing who have attended classes regularly, completed all of the assignments and midterm, and are not currently failing the course.

Course Policy on the Use of Artificial Intelligence

In BIOL 111, the use of Artificial Intelligence, including ChatGPT and similar tools to complete (or support the completion) of any form of assignment or assessment in this course is not allowed, with the exception of using iNaturalist for the Ecology Activity. Use of other AI tools for academic purposes is considered academic misconduct. Because the information generated by AI tools may be unreliable, fabricated, and/or biased, BIOL111 students are encouraged to use more scholarly, academic, and peer-reviewed sources (e.g., the course e-text, other academic texts and/or websites, field guides) when searching for information.

Academic Honesty

Plagiarism or any form of cheating is not tolerated in this course. Please see the UBC rules on Academic Honesty and Standards at www.science.ubc.ca/students/new/conduct. These rules apply to all exams and assignments.

During the exam period, you are not allowed to engage in a chat/conversation with anyone except your instructors and/or exam invigilators, even if you finish the exam early.

We take academic integrity very seriously – individuals caught cheating and/or plagiarizing will receive zero marks on their exams and have their cases referred to the Associate Head of Biology and/or the Dean of Science. Please ensure that you understand what constitutes Academic Misconduct (see the link above).

A note on sharing course materials:

A lot of material will be provided to you in this course: class lecture slides, quizzes, practice problems, etc. According to UBC copyright laws, it is illegal for anyone to post or distribute any course materials on other websites or to other groups. Please refrain from distributing course materials in any manner. Only students registered in BIOL 111 this term have legal access to these course materials.

Recording is NOT permitted during class. In-person classes will be recorded and available to students for review. Due to copyright laws and restrictions, no recording may be shared or posted on any website without explicit permission from your instructor.

For other issues regarding Academic Regulations, please refer to the UBC Calendar, Chapter V, Student Conduct and Discipline, [here](#).

Other Student Responsibilities

Centre for Accessibility:

- If you require academic accommodations, you should contact the Centre for Accessibility (<https://students.ubc.ca/about-student-services/centre-for-accessibility>).
- If you are already registered with the Centre for Accessibility, please submit any letters to me by the end of the second week of class. Paper or electronic copies are accepted. Exam accommodations must be arranged at least one week in advance of the exam.

Health and well-being:

- If you are experiencing problems that are affecting your performance in the class (e.g., health, family, work, etc.), please contact a member of the teaching team as soon as possible so we can discuss what resources are available to help you succeed in this course. You do not need to discuss or divulge the specifics of personal problems to us; we can help direct you to the appropriate resources at the university.
- Here is a link to a Faculty of Science hub for student mental health and wellbeing: <https://science.ubc.ca/students/wellbeing>

Steps to Success in BIOL 111

- Incorporate recall/retrieval methods into your study routine (e.g., create flashcards, draw diagrams/concept maps, form study teams). Evidence suggests that students who depend solely on passive study techniques (e.g., reading notes or rereading the textbook) do not perform as well on exams as those students who also include recall/retrieval activities.
- Consider using a space-repetition approach to studying (rather than cramming). Space-repetition is an evidence-based study approach that involves repeatedly reviewing information over multiple short study sessions using active recall (i.e. recall retrieval method). The UBC Department of Statistics found that students who left 2-3 days between revisiting concepts performed significantly better on exams than students who used a different approach to studying. They said “students need to begin to forget” (the concept) before revisiting. Other UBC Professors (e.g., Dr. Graf) recommend increasing the time between revisiting concepts (e.g., the next day, two days later, one week later).
- To master new terminology, use the new terms in at least seven novel ways
- Divide your study time into time blocks of no more than 1.5 hours (beyond this point there are diminishing returns), spaced 2-3 days apart for any one concept.
- Review course learning objectives (on Canvas>Course Information) to see if you have met these goals
- Go to office hours (don’t be afraid to come and talk to us; we love questions!)
- Post any questions that you may have on the course discussion board (Piazza)
- Email/visit instructor/teaching assistant if concepts are still unclear
- Get enough sleep (<https://www.newscientist.com/article/2132258-the-brain-starts-to-eat-itself-after-chronic-sleep-deprivation/>)!

Useful contacts

- Tammy Tromba, Senior Program Assistant, Biology: tromba@zoology.ubc.ca
- Biology Program Web Site (for those planning to go on in Biology): www.biology.ubc.ca
- Comprehensive learning support: <https://learningcommons.ubc.ca/>
- AMS tutoring services: <https://www.ams.ubc.ca/student-services/tutoring/>

Other resources

- Faculty of Science Student Wellbeing hub: <https://science.ubc.ca/students/wellbeing>
- Budget-Friendly Meals and Food Hub Market on campus: <https://foodhub.ubc.ca/>